PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #66 · ABUSE

“I should have fought harder or left sooner. Because I didn’t, I must have agreed to it.”

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Where it often comes from

After harm, people torture themselves with the exit they can see now. “I should have fought harder. I should have left sooner. Because I didn’t, I agreed.” That uses today’s knowledge against the person you were then. Freezing, staying, hoping, having nowhere to go, loving someone, or being afraid are not consent. Not leaving is not the same thing as agreeing. You do not owe anyone a story of why you stayed. If you are not safe right now, call 911. You can also call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. If a child is being hurt, call Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. A counselor can help you at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do this alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

The Lord knows our frame. He has compassion as a father has compassion on his children. There is no condemnation in Christ for the person who survived the way they could. He is near the brokenhearted. He binds up the brokenhearted. Jesus says not to let your heart be troubled. These verses do not scold you for the strategy that kept you alive. Agreement is a free yes. Fear, confusion, and having no safe exit are not a yes.

> *“As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust”* (Psalm 103:13–14).

Also see

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners” (Isaiah 61:1).

> “Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid” (John 14:27).

Common self-statements

- I agreed because I stayed.
- If I had been braver, it would have stopped.
- A strong person would have left the first time.
- I have no right to complain now.
- God wanted me to endure it.
- Leaving now would prove I could have left then, so I must not.

Common logical errors

- Hindsight bias: Blaming your past self for not using an exit you can see only now.
- All-or-nothing thinking: If you did not fight perfectly or leave immediately, you agreed.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed of staying and calling the shame consent.
- Personalization: Making your survival strategy the cause of their choice.

Challenging questions

- What choices did I actually have then, not the ones I can imagine now?
- Does staying, freezing, or hoping equal a free yes?
- Would I tell a friend that not leaving meant they agreed?
- Who benefits if I keep this charge against myself?
- What would getting help now look like, without a trial about the past?
- What does “He knows our frame” mean for the person I was then?

Truth summary

> Not fighting or not leaving was not agreement. I survived the way I could, and that was not consent.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

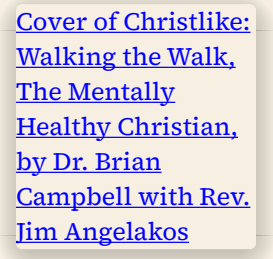
- Guilt/Shame
- Thinking, Healthy
- Fear
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Help

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Suffering

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Grace does not put you on trial for a door you could not open then.

Grace Wins — Matthew West
Grace wins over the charge that surviving was the same as agreeing.

Do It Again — Steven Curtis Chapman
You can begin again without first proving you should have left sooner.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
Christ's victory is not a prize reserved for the person who fought perfectly.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I should have fought harder or left sooner. Because I didn't, I must have agreed to it."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I should have fought harder or left sooner. Because I didn't, I must have agreed to it." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What choices did I actually have then, not the ones I can imagine now?
- ☐ Does staying, freezing, or hoping equal a free yes?
- ☐ Would I tell a friend that not leaving meant they agreed?
- ☐ Who benefits if I keep this charge against myself?
- ☐ What would getting help now look like, without a trial about the past?
- ☐ What does "He knows our frame" mean for the person I was then?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Not fighting or not leaving was not agreement. I survived the way I could, and that was not consent.
- ☐ Staying was not the same as agreeing.
- ☐ I judge my past self with facts I may not have had then.
- ☐ Freezing or hoping is a human response, not permission.
- ☐ God knows my frame. He is not cross-examining me.
- ☐ I can leave or get help now without proving I should have sooner.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 103:13–14
  "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."
- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When you accused yourself of agreeing: Each day, write down one moment when not leaving felt like consent. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 103:14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God knows my frame. Not leaving was not a yes.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone. If you are not safe right now, call 911 or 1-800-799-7233.

- ☐ Retire "I agreed." When the sentence comes, answer, "Survival is not consent," and stop. No replay of events.
- ☐ Ask your counselor to help you look at then versus now. Stop if you feel flooded.
- ☐ One present step, not a verdict on the past: a call to 1-800-799-7233, a locked door, or a plan with your counselor.
- ☐ Read Psalm 103:13–14 when the "I should have" voice starts.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I should have fought harder or left sooner. Because I didn't, I must have agreed to it.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I did not call survival consent
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I should have fought harder or left sooner.~~

~~Because I didn't, I must have agreed to it~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have called my survival a yes. You know my frame. Teach me that not leaving was not agreement, and give me help for the life I have now. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.